ONE-OFF SHIURIM

What Can We Say About God?

Derech Hashem, Maamar HaIkarim

Sefer: Maamar HaIkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar HaIkarim, essay 1: the Creator **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 19 May 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A new section: the essays on fundamentals

The class opened on Lag BaOmer with a new section. Having finished the four parts of Derech Hashem the previous week with the blessings on misvot, the group now turned to Maamar HaIkarim, the Ramhal's ten short essays on the fundamentals of faith. Some are revision of the book, some are new. The first essay, on the Creator, is a summary of the first chapters learned almost two years earlier. The Rabbi said it is really about "what God is and what God isn't".

The Jewish definition of God

The Ramhal opens: there is one Being, the Master of all existence, who created everything when He wished. He also sustains it for as long as He wishes and is in full control of it. The Rabbi stressed that all three parts are essential. A person who believes that God created the world and then left it to run by nature does not believe in God in the Jewish sense. "You may believe in a different kind of God, but not the Jewish definition of what God is."

God is complete in every kind of perfection and lacks nothing. He depends on nothing and nothing affects Him. He has no beginning and no end, and there was never a time when He did not exist. The Rabbi linked this to time itself: time is a creation and a limitation. This is how the Rambam answers the old question of free will and God's knowledge. We cannot understand how God can know what we will freely choose, because we are bound by past, present and future. For a God above time, the question does not arise.

If nothing affects God, why do we pray?

The Rabbi raised a question from the verses. The Torah speaks of a "pleasing aroma" and of God being pleased or saddened by our actions, and in prayer we ask Him to move from the seat of judgment to the seat of mercy. How can we affect Him?

A participant answered that God has set up a structure in which our pleas can delay or change things. The Rabbi agreed and added: God has created a system in which He has, as it were, made Himself dependent on our responses, our prayers and our actions. But that is His choice, and He could end it at any time. He compared it to a parent who controls all of a child's money

and decides to give and take according to the child's behaviour. The parent is not really dependent on the child, and can break the whole system whenever he wants.

To explain how God sustains everything, the Rabbi repeated a thought experiment from the start of the series. Close your eyes and spend two minutes imagining your own universe in full detail. Then think about something else, such as dinner or next week's meetings. What happened to that universe? It is gone. It existed only while you kept thinking about it. "It's exactly the same with God." The world exists only because He is constantly sustaining it.

Perfect, simple and without a body

Because God is perfect, any explanation of suffering that implies He is unable to intervene is mistaken. The group had studied seven or eight explanations of why bad things happen to good people. The Rabbi mentioned the well-known book When Bad Things Happen to Good People, whose premise is that God cannot or will not intervene. "That's not our God. Our God is one who is perfect, and if He wanted to, can intervene."

God is also absolutely simple, with no multiplicity and no parts. That is why He can have no body. However large a body you imagine, it has dimensions and boundaries, and God has none. Simplicity also means we must not picture God as a combination of separate traits, a merciful streak plus a truthful streak and so on. The Thirteen Attributes are not thirteen parts of God. The Rabbi used his familiar analogy: one sunlight seen through different coloured lenses. Through a red lens it is red, through a green lens it is green, but it is the same light. God's one light reaches us through the lens of mercy, of kindness, of truth.

So when the Torah speaks of God's eyes, or of God "coming down", we must reinterpret it. The Shekhinah is not a separate part of God sent down to a place. "That's a big mistake people make." To say the Shekhinah is at the Kotel means that God's presence is more strongly felt there, nothing more. To divide God into parts would take away from His oneness.

Only borrowed words

Above all, says the Ramhal, God's true essence cannot be grasped, in this world or the next. We can only say what He is not. A participant asked whether we may at least say that God wants to do good. The Rabbi accepted this in a qualified sense: the nature of good is to do good, so in that sense, "in inverted commas", God wants to give us good. Another participant put it as a structure that leans towards good, which our choices then disturb, and the Rabbi agreed.

The Ramhal ends the essay with a warning. Whenever we describe God, all our words and adjectives are "only in borrowed terms", because human language was made to describe a world of boundaries and physical things. Be very careful with this. Even the most compassionate person's compassion is tangible and describable, and nothing like God's.

Summary

- The Jewish God created everything, constantly sustains it, and is in full control; believing in a God who walked away from the world is not the same belief.
- God is perfect, unaffected and above time; He chose to create a system in which our prayers and actions matter.

- God has no parts and no body; His one light reaches us through different "lenses" such as mercy and kindness.
- We can only say what God is not, and every description of Him in the Torah is in borrowed terms.

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